

REVIEWS

165

Eight Hours for What We Will: Workers and Leisure in an Industrial City, 1870-1920. By Roy Rosenzweig (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1983. xi plus 304 pp. \$29.95).

The industrial conditions of Worcester provide the setting for this investigation of workers and leisure between 1870 and 1920. During these fifty years the second largest city of Massachusetts produced wire and related metals, machines and machine tools, boots and shoes, with textiles leading the miscellany of other goods, at a rate which placed Worcester in the mid-twenties in the higher rank of manufacturing cities of the United States. The presence of powerful local WASP industrialists and weak trade unions characterized the social aspects of these diverse economic activities, with the working force rooted in strong ethnic communities. The addition of a large number of Swedes around 1890 to the dominant Irish and a smaller group of French Canadian laborers revived the split between Catholics and Protestants, which had diminished with the waning of native-born workers. At the turn of the century the arrival of Italians, Poles, Jews, Lithuanians, Finns, Greeks, Syrians, and Armenians further intensified the divisions.

This is the distinct setting the author utilizes to probe the interaction between Worcester's economic and social conditions and the workers' use of leisure in saloons, on the Fourth of July, in parks and playgrounds as well as in amusement parks and movie houses. He relies on a variety of sources, most noticeable among them newspapers, credit reports, court records, manuscript censuses, city directories, municipal and state documents as well as the papers of a city marshal and the accounts of the parks commission and the playground commission. The resulting case studies trace not only the struggle over specific forms of recreation between laborers and self-styled guardians of the so-called proper behavior but also such related issues as temperance, the perceived threat of types of relaxation to property, family, and country, and the commercialization of entertainment. The investigation illustrates the strength of a system of values emphasizing community and stability, which differed from the dominant American credo oriented to individualism and mobility. Using Raymond Williams's terms, the author designates the workers' forms of leisure as "alternative" rather than "oppositional;" a sequence of statements-by-action, so to say, made daily by people relaxing in their own ways and on their own terms, and not as a challenge to other practices or as a design for making over society.

The insights are linked to the book's conclusion by the suggestion that the contest over the use of leisure "became an arena of class struggle," with the reader being admonished not to "be deceived into thinking that Worcester was a city without class conflicts." (p. 225) The argument seems to rest on the plausible ideas that class conflict may express itself in many ways and that any relatively free society may show class struggle. However, the author does not marshal empirical evidence to demonstrate that the workers of Worcester used leisure as a weapon in the class struggle nor does he sustain that point in the face of a consumerism that inextricably pulled rich and poor into an American mold. Analogously, his references to Emma Goldman's indifference to Worcester as a possible battle ground in the class struggle may not indicate that she had a limited "understanding of the American proletariat" (p. 9) but that she did not detect the city's workers using forms of recreation as a tool of class warfare. These considerations also place limits on the author's conclusion that popular recreation lost its significance as a possible measure of conflict between workers and industrialists after the commercialization of leisure in the opening decades of the twentieth century.